

12-14% Body Fat Balances Work, Life & Gym Perfectly

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Executive Summary

After completing a gruelling 2-month project, Chris outlines his proven system for returning to consistent training: prioritise legs first, ramp weight progressively, eat cleaner when not training, use explosive cardio, and embrace a sustainable 12-14% body fat lifestyle over chasing extreme aesthetics.

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The Context: Coming Back After a Big Work Push 0:00

- Just finished a massive project that took roughly 2 months
 - The gym took a backseat entirely during this period
 - Result: mega fatigue, desire to watch TV, eat junk food, and do nothing work-related
- The challenge is psychological: maintaining momentum and returning to relentless training after a long break is genuinely hard
- His overarching principle for staying in shape over the years as a natural athlete (nearly 34 years old) is **the aggregation of marginal gains**
 - Concept: improve multiple areas of life by a small percentage and they accumulate into one large compounded gain
 - Staying consistent — even imperfectly — is the embodiment of this principle
- This video lays out exactly how he returns to routine after every major break (travel, content pushes, brand/business sprints)

Rule 1: Start With Legs First 1:54

- Counterintuitive choice, but deliberate — legs are the first thing to shrink when you're sedentary

- Sitting at a desk, sitting on planes, working long hours = legs atrophy fastest
- Upper body stays relatively bigger because you're still picking things up incidentally
- This is an **"eat the frog" strategy** — do the hardest thing first
 - Cracking legs on day one signals to yourself: "We're underway. We're back into it."
- The alternative trap: start with chest and arms, look aesthetic quickly, then keep avoiding leg day
 - When leg day comes back around, motivation is still low — you haven't broken the mental barrier
- Starting with legs gives you that psychological swing: "We're training again. We're getting serious."
- Practical note from the session: using the leg curl machine, leaning forward targets the hamstrings specifically

Rule 2: Ramp Weight Progressively — Don't Ease In Too Slowly 3:27

- Before lifting, run a quick internal audit:
 - Am I injured?
 - Are any muscles tight?
 - Have I been flying too much?
 - Have I been eating well?
 - How is my sleep? (During the project: only 4-5-6 hours per night)
- Mental model: assume strength has dropped by roughly **5-10%** and start conservatively — but be ready to go up fast
- Example from the session:
 - Started at 20 kg dumbbells to feel things out
 - First working set jumped to 40 kg
 - Then straight to 50 kg — felt okay, completed 6 reps (vs. usual 8-10)
- Key insight: he was only **about 2 reps weaker on average** (4 reps maximum) than when training consistently
 - Strength is largely retained even through long breaks if you lift heavy when you do train
- The process he recommends:
 - Do 5 reps at a moderate weight — if it feels strong, go heavier
 - Do 5 reps at heavier weight — if still strong, go heavier again
 - Final set: 3 reps at the heaviest weight you can manage — real struggle
 - That's enough to feel like your muscles have been worked for the first time in weeks or months
- **Common mistake to avoid:** going too extreme on return (e.g., a 7-mile run followed by a 20-mile bike ride)
 - Ask instead: "What's sustainable? What's enjoyable? What do I actually want to do?"
- Another common mistake: fat beginners jumping on the treadmill for an hour
 - "You don't need to join a gym to do that" — and it has minimal effect on body composition

- Best thing: lift really, really heavy



Rule 3: Diet Gets Cleaner When You're Not Training 6:31

- When not hitting the gym, he stays in a **small calorie deficit and eats only good food**
 - "If anything, my diet becomes even more immaculate because I know I'm not training"
- The two-evils trap: most people stop training AND eat junk simultaneously
 - Reasoning: "I'm not training so it doesn't really matter, I'll fix it afterwards"
 - His counter: why have both things bad when you can keep one under control?
- The preferred outcome: be slightly skinnier but **lean as hell**
 - When you get a pump again after returning to the gym, you look enormous
 - vs. losing muscle and gaining fat at the same time — worst of both worlds
- Psychological reframe: making a bad situation worse is a built-in human tendency — resist it
 - Example used: someone experiences grief and responds by getting drunk and making more destructive choices
 - Same logic applies to fitness: can't train → don't also blow up your diet
- Caveat on who this advice is for:
 - This is NOT an excuse for people with a standard 9-to-5 job (40 hours a week)
 - "A nine-to-five is child's play. You've got enough time to do so much. Don't be lazy. Don't be soft."
 - The advice is for people with genuinely extreme work pressure — big projects, heavy travel, real business demands



Rule 4: Explosive Cardio — The Three Best Options 8:01

- Three rules for people who travel/work heavily and treat fitness as something to maintain rather than maximise
- **Rule 1 — Explosive Cardio.** Three best options:

Type	How to do it
Boxing	Smash the bag with full combinations — by 60 seconds you must be completely out of breath. Interval structure: go hard, rest, repeat. NOT light tapping.
Sprinting	Hill sprints preferred (better for knees and injury prevention). ~40-50m sprints, walk back down, repeat. Then shorter ones. Quick, done.
Swimming	Swim quickly and explosively. Teaches lean body maintenance. Dopamine hit, then back to work.

- Swimming highlighted as potentially **the best single exercise** for maintaining physique when busy
 - Has access to pools at villas they visit around the world
 - Two Onem team members (Alex and Peter) are former swimmers and have been coaching him on diving and technique

- "It does something to your body that nothing else does in my opinion"
- Accessible if you have pool facilities; acknowledged not everyone does
- Key principle across all three: the cardio must be **explosive and interval-based** — not steady-state plodding
- This combination (heavy lifting + explosive cardio) keeps the body intact even during high-stress, high-cortisol periods



Make Up For Lost Time When You Have It 9:56

- Example from the filming of this video: **three gym sessions in 24 hours**
 - Session 1: all the footage from day one
 - Session 2: that same night
 - Session 3: the following morning
- Core philosophy: when time frees up, go all in — don't stay at maintenance pace
 - "When you can fit it in, fit it in. When you can squeeze it in, squeeze it in."
 - Do double sessions when the schedule allows
 - "When I have time, I really train. I'll do 3 hours per day — and then that makes up for it when you can't train."
- Simple equation: compress hard training into available windows; don't spread it out lazily



The Philosophy: 12-14% Body Fat Over Elite Aesthetics 10:42

- Acknowledges the appeal of wanting to be maximally jacked/shredded — "I get it. I think it's a young man's game."
- His personal conclusion after years of pushing for elite gains:

"I would much rather be 14% body fat and living an unbelievable lifestyle of restaurants, travel, having fun — everything that life has to offer — and be a guy that has a ton of money because he's prioritised that, has a family, has everything... rather than a guy who is absolutely shredded but his life hasn't really gone anywhere."

- **Fitness ROI has a ceiling; wealth ROI is inexhaustible** in terms of life quality
- **10% body fat is miserable.** His sustainable range:
 - ~14% when life is full (travel, restaurants, flexibility)
 - ~12% when he has time to really focus
- At 14%, he can:
 - Go out for meals with his girlfriend
 - Travel freely
 - Drink a sugary coffee without stress

- "I'm up for a good time. I want to have a good life across the board."
- On steroid users:
 - Doesn't believe average jacked YouTubers on steroids can outlift him on performance metrics (strength, cardio, flexibility, boxing)
 - Steroid use characterised as a **selfish decision** — purely aesthetic, for attraction, not for life quality or family
 - Warning: guys starting steroids at 21 risk heart attacks by 30, fertility issues, and other serious health consequences
 - References ongoing deaths in the fitness industry as evidence the extreme path is not alpha — it's dangerous
 - "The most alpha strategy is providing for people and being alive."
- On optimal body fat for **sporting performance, strength, health, sex drive, and happiness**:
 - **12-16% body fat** is the sweet spot
 - Examples: Fedor, Daniel Cormier, Jon Jones, Tyson Fury — elite fighters who are not shredded (estimated 16-18%)
 - Moses Atuma cited as one of the best boxers in the world — moves brilliantly at roughly 16% body fat
 - Going sub-10% without steroids makes a "good life" nearly impossible to sustain
- On diminishing returns from extreme attractiveness:
 - Past a certain point of looks, you become a "pretty boy" women aren't really interested in
 - "Better to be big, scary, wealthy, and a good provider" than looks-maxed
 - References Clavicular (likely a social media figure) as an example of someone who doesn't appear happy despite elite physique — got beaten up by an older man, got rejected by girls in Paris
- Final take: if you have great genetics and can achieve both elite physique AND great life, do it — but don't sacrifice life quality chasing aesthetics
 - **Massive ROI for men in boosting income and maintaining 12-14% body fat** — this is the optimal trade-off